

HONDUE LAST-TETHER

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Summary

Hondue Last-Tether is a dwarven singer, instrumentalist, free captain, and former exterior maintenance rigger from **Theosis**. His music combines forge-watch work songs, layered dwarven vocals, strings, heavy percussion, electric instruments, and modern popular production. He first became famous after surviving a catastrophic separation during the **Shredder Passage**, after which Erbium Industries used his recovery and music as evidence that technical skill, sacrifice, and corporate support could carry a worker into the highest levels of Settled Systems culture.

Hondue later escaped aboard his own concert vessel after corporate security discovered that his crew had been transporting medicine, repair components, and passengers outside authorized channels. The vessel now travels as the **Last Warrant**, carrying Hondue and his crew between concerts, salvage operations, relief deliveries, and raids against Erbium repossession and detention vessels.



Hondue was born **Hondue of Clan Tavran** and raised within one of the lower industrial districts of Crown Meridian. He entered his clan's forge watches as an atmospheric rigger and pressure-envelope inspector, working outside the inhabited envelopes during docking repairs, stabilizer inspections, sulfur decontamination, and preparations for the Shredder Passage.

Hondue was already known among the watch for singing over the shared channel during long exterior assignments. Some songs kept a common work rhythm while crews shifted ballast, secured guide rails, or crossed maintenance frames. Others helped workers remain awake, confirm who was still responding, and fill the time while one team waited for another to complete a repair.

THE LAST TETHER

Hondue received his title during a Shredder Passage accident involving **Frame Twelve**, an exterior maintenance structure attached to one of Crown Meridian's lower pressure envelopes. Atmospheric shear tore the frame's work cage away from its guide rail and pulled several workers beyond the reach of the nearest access lock. Two primary tethers failed during the separation, leaving Hondue attached to the final intact line while the rest of the crew transferred themselves back toward the city.

The rescue damaged his suit and exposed his left side to the surrounding atmosphere. His hands and face suffered severe chemical burns, while debris destroyed his left eye, crushed part of his neck, and damaged his forearm beyond ordinary reconstruction.

The last recording recovered from the work channel contained Hondue singing between rescue instructions. His voice continued beneath warning alarms, suit telemetry, and the names of workers moving along the tether. Erbium's official report described the accident as a successful personnel-recovery procedure, though a member of Hondue's forge watch later released part of the channel recording through a clan archive along with earlier repair requests concerning Frame Twelve. Lower-deck workers began calling him **Last-Tether** before he left medical care.

RECONSTRUCTION

Erbium Industries financed much of Hondue's reconstruction after the work-channel recording began circulating outside Theosis. His left eye was replaced with a pressure-rated industrial optic descended from the inspection equipment he had used during exterior work. It identifies surface stress, heat variation, chemical residue, and pressure leakage, and its red aperture became one of his most recognizable features.

The augmentation around his neck reinforces damaged vertebrae and replaces portions of his larynx and upper airway. Its resonant chambers restored his ability to speak and gave his singing voice a deeper mechanical undertone. Early producers attempted to smooth the sound during recording, though Hondue required that the resonance remain audible.

His left forearm contains a retractable seam blade used for cutting pressure fabric, restraint cable, damaged suit material, and emergency access panels. The blade incorporates his clan crystal and represents the current form of the weapon given to him at birth. The sulfur damage across his hands and the left fringe of his face could be treated, softened, or covered, though Hondue leaves it visible.

FIRST RECORDINGS

Hondue recorded his earliest commercial songs while still completing physical rehabilitation. His first major release, **Keep Her Level**, was adapted from an altitude-adjustment song used during Shredder preparations. The recording begins with a single voice and the rhythm of tools striking a maintenance rail before strings,

drums, electric guitar, and a full forge-watch chorus enter as the song progresses.

The release spread first through clan archives, maintenance channels, freight crews, and lower-deck settlements. Commercial distribution followed after workers had already copied it across several systems. Erbium licensed the recording for safety broadcasts and public memorial programming, and Hondue began appearing in corporate campaigns discussing equipment compliance, emergency readiness, and the importance of trained personnel.

His sulfur-scarred hands, industrial augmentations, and forge-watch title made him easy to recognize. Erbium presented him as a worker whose discipline and recovery demonstrated the strength of the systems surrounding him. Hondue used the attention to discuss the workers who had been on Frame Twelve, the repair requests filed before the accident, and the crew members whose names appeared in the channel recording.

THE SPONSORED YEARS

Hondue remained under Erbium sponsorship for several years. His performances grew from lower-deck halls and clan gatherings into major concert venues throughout the Settled Systems. His touring band included dwarven string musicians, forge-watch singers, industrial percussionists, former riggers, and several members of the crew who had worked with him on Theosis.

His music retained the structure of work songs. Verses carried instructions, names, measurements, warnings, and places, while choruses used short responses that could be sung by a full maintenance crew or a stadium audience. Hondue's public statements remained careful during this period, though he regularly discussed missing maintenance records, denied repair requests, craft-warrant liability, and workers blamed for systems they had requested permission to shut down.

When asked whether Erbium knew Frame Twelve was unsafe, Hondue usually gave the same answer:

The inspection was signed. The repair request was stamped. The frame was kept in service.

A portion of his income funded pressure-equipment replacement, sulfur-rot treatment, clan mutual-aid accounts, and transportation for dwarves returning to Vuddar for reorientation.

THE WARRANTED RETURN

Erbium assigned Hondue and his touring company a converted personnel transport called the **Warranted Return**. The vessel carried musicians, equipment, production staff, corporate handlers, temporary stage structures, and several cargo holds large enough to transport complete concert installations. It traveled through major ports, extraction settlements, company stations, and communities that rarely received independent civilian traffic.

Touring exposed Hondue to workers beyond Theosis. He met discharged miners who could not afford passage home, settlements waiting months for replacement filters, androids avoiding component repossession, and civic-service crews whose contracts had been extended while they were already in transit. The unused sections of the Warranted Return soon began carrying medicine, pressure components, unregistered repair parts, and passengers.

Some cargo was purchased using ticket revenue or clan mutual-aid funds. Some was donated by workers attending the concerts. Other shipments came from Erbium stores after the company had refused to release them to the settlements requesting them. Stage cases gained false walls, empty speaker housings carried medical supplies, and touring manifests listed replacement lighting rigs that weighed as much as filtration equipment. Discharged workers joined the production crew for the exact length of time required to reach another system, and Hondue's musicians, technicians, and riggers became the vessel's first smuggling crew.

CUTTING THE WARRANT LOOSE

The operation continued for eleven standard months before corporate security boarded the Warranted Return during a refueling stop. Security personnel discovered several hidden passengers and a shipment of pressure regulators registered for destruction after failing Erbium recertification. The regulators remained serviceable under the standards used by the settlement waiting to receive them.

The boarding team attempted to seize the cargo, detain several crew members, and remove Hondue from the ship under the terms of his performance contract. Hondue's crew sealed the internal pressure doors between the boarding party and the bridge, while former exterior riggers released the vessel's docking clamps manually as the port authority processed the seizure order. Hondue used his forearm blade to cut the final emergency restraint.

The Warranted Return departed with the boarding team locked inside an empty rehearsal compartment. Hondue released them in a pressure-rated escape module beyond the port's traffic perimeter. Erbium classified the vessel as stolen company property, and Hondue removed its registry placard and renamed it the **Last Warrant**.

THE LAST WARRANT

The Last Warrant now operates as a concert ship, salvage vessel, smuggling transport, and pirate craft. Its crew includes musicians, mechanics, former exterior riggers, discharged service workers, freight specialists, and several people who originally joined the sponsored tour. Stage equipment shares cargo space with pressure doors, boarding cable, spare life-support systems, hidden bunks, salvage tools, and goods awaiting delivery to settlements unable to purchase them through authorized channels.

Concert lighting has been adapted for exterior salvage and boarding operations. Stage winches move cargo and secure disabled vessels, amplifier housings conceal tools, weapons, and replacement parts, and the main performance chamber can become temporary shelter for passengers during long crossings.

Hondue favors corporate repossession craft, detention transports, abandoned extraction sites, and freight vessels carrying supplies withheld from their intended destination. He broadcasts a warning before most interceptions and gives crews time to surrender their manifests, weapons, and custody records. Workers under transport are offered passage aboard the Last Warrant, while captured crews are usually left with enough fuel, air, food, and functioning navigation equipment to reach port.

The vessel sells salvaged cargo when fuel, repairs, or wages require it. A share of most valuable captures enters clan mutual-aid accounts or reaches settlements through off-stamp supply networks. Hondue calls himself a working musician and licensed salvage captain, citing a license that was revoked several years ago.

MUSIC

Hondue continues to release music from the Last Warrant through independent relays, clan archives, concert recordings, and unauthorized rebroadcasts. His earlier songs remain grounded in Theosis, forge watches, exterior labor, and the people who maintained the buoyant cities:

- ◆ **Keep Her Level**
- ◆ **Three Lights Through the Sulfur**
- ◆ **Ghost Minutes**
- ◆ **Tetherline Home**
- ◆ **Rain Upon Vuddar**
- ◆ **Every Hand Holds Air**

His later work draws from shipboard labor, intercepted cargo, unauthorized passage, and life beyond Erbium-controlled routes:

- ◆ **Cut the Warrant Loose**
- ◆ **No Port Owns the Air**
- ◆ **Leave Them Fuel**
- ◆ **Seven Hands at the Boarding Rail**
- ◆ **Company Cargo**
- ◆ **Bring the Detained Aboard**
- ◆ **Off-Stamp and Outward Bound**
- ◆ **The Last Warrant**

His recordings commonly begin with a single voice or instrument. Additional voices enter in overlapping responses, followed by strings, drums, electric guitar, industrial percussion, and sampled machinery. Live audiences frequently sing the work responses while Hondue carries the lead verses. Concerts aboard the Last Warrant have been performed in independent ports, repair yards, clanholdings, cargo stations, and the open holds of vessels traveling alongside it.

PUBLIC PERSONA

Hondue encourages much of the image that has grown around him. He performs in heavy work boots, bright shirts, forge-watch jewelry, and coats modeled after early Drift captains. His concerts use ship bells, docking clamps, maintenance tools, and recorded engine noise as percussion. Crew members enter through mock airlocks, and several songs begin with boarding calls, cargo counts, or the reading of a disputed warrant.

His clothing, stage entrances, broadcasts, and boarding warnings have made him one of the Settled Systems' most recognizable models of popular piracy. The performance also serves practical purposes. Much of his concert hardware also serves as salvage hardware, his stage and boarding crews share personnel, and a dramatic entrance through an airlock requires the same timing, seals, and cable work as moving between vessels.

Children buy replica tether hooks, toy seam blades, and bright coats patterned after his stage clothing. Workers paint the Last Warrant's broken registry mark onto helmets, tool cases, cargo doors, and unauthorized supply lockers. Fans argue about which parts of Hondue's pirate persona are theatrical, and his crew rarely answers.

PUBLIC REPUTATION

Hondue remains one of the most recognizable dwarves in the Settled Systems. Older Erbium safety campaigns still circulate with his image, while current corporate broadcasts describe him as a contract violator, cargo thief, propagandist, and organizer of intersystem piracy. The difference between the campaigns has made the original advertisements valuable collectibles.

Among lower-deck workers and dwarven forge watches, Hondue remains closely associated with mutual aid, maintenance accountability, and resistance to craft-warrant abuse. Independent settlements hire the Last Warrant for performances, salvage, transportation, or protection. Erbium-aligned ports issue detention orders when the vessel enters their jurisdiction, while other governments tolerate its presence until one of their own ships appears on Hondue's cargo records.

Corporate media claims that Hondue uses worker grievances to build a profitable outlaw brand. Hondue earns considerable money from recordings, concerts, merchandise, salvage, and captured cargo, with a substantial portion leaving the ship through medical funds, equipment purchases, legal assistance, transport costs, and payments to the families of detained crew members. His supporters call him a free captain, Erbium calls him a pirate, and Hondue answers to both.